Little Fox Readers

Level 5

Journey to the West 104

The Tang Monk and the River



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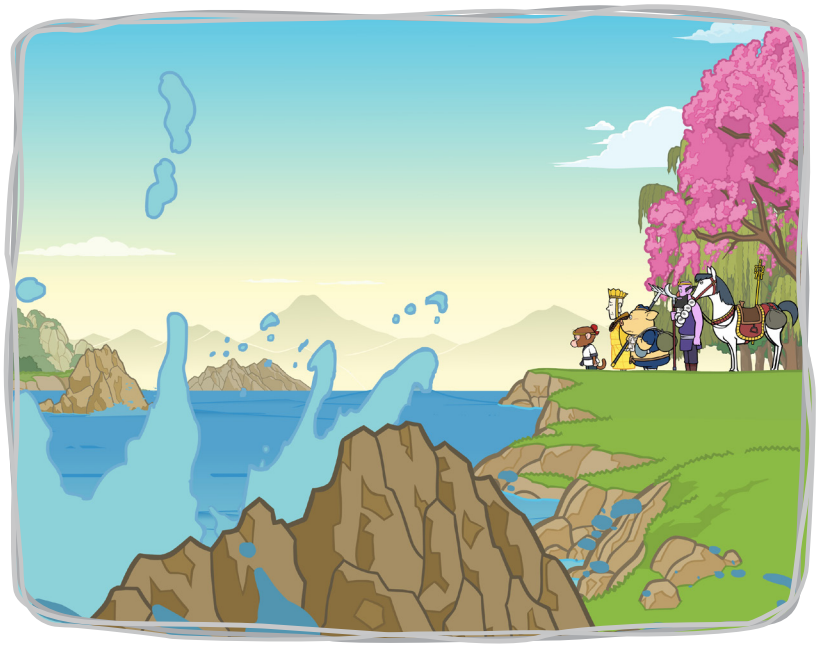
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The Tang Monk and the River



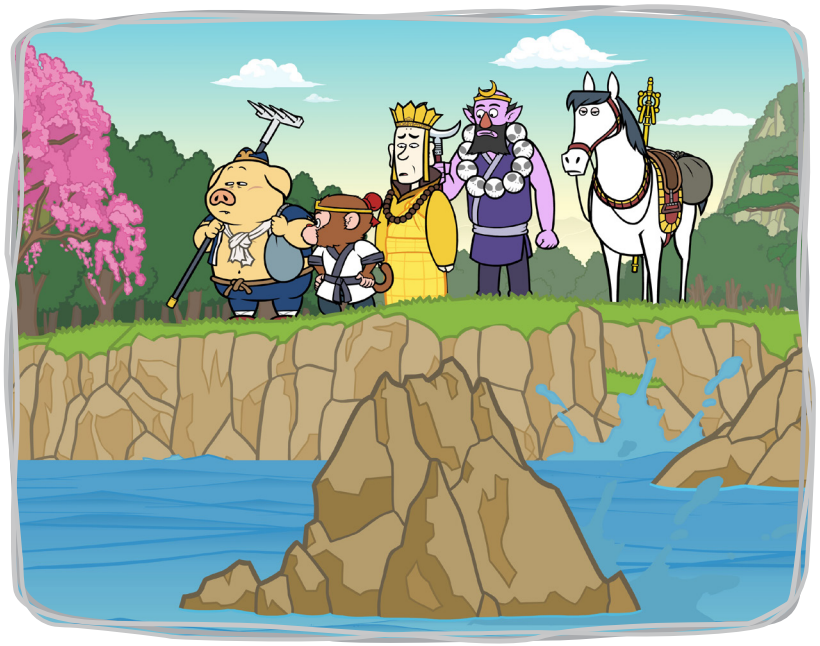
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Wukong and his companions walked through the Western Paradise. The road weaved through a field of flowers and toward the Spirit Mountain.

Bajie looked up at the huge mountain and shook his head. “It won’t be easy to climb that.”

Wukong laughed. “Don’t ask me to carry you!”



The travelers soon arrived at a river with a strong current. Waves crashed into jagged rocks, spraying water everywhere.

“This river looks dangerous,” said Wujing. “But we must cross it to get to the Spirit Mountain.”

Bajie sighed. “We will never be able to cross this river safely. Let’s just go home.”

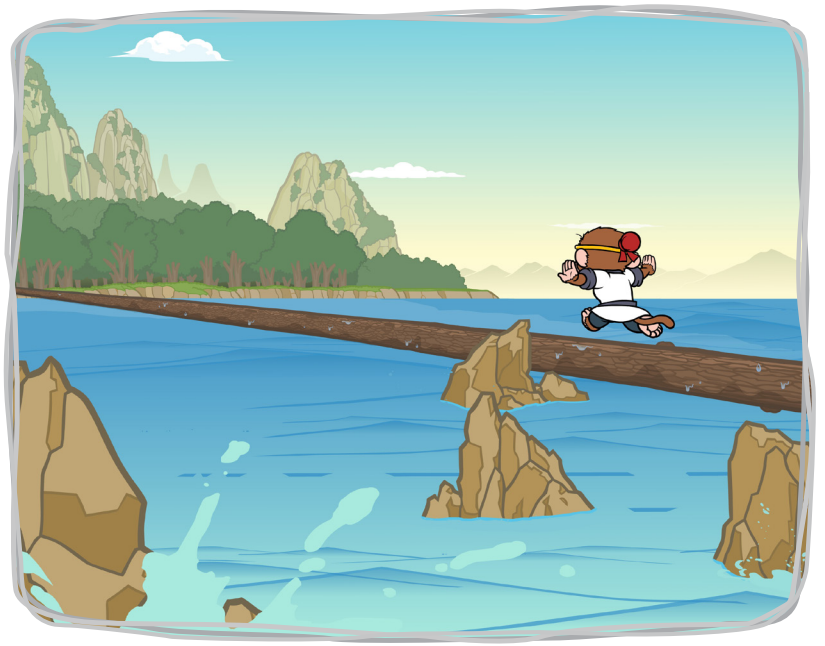
“Nonsense,” said Wukong. “Look over there.”



The monkey pointed upstream. A thin log lay across the river. It wobbled and shook as the water rushed under it.

The Tang Monk looked at the log. “Don’t be silly, Wukong. We can’t walk across that log—it’s too thin. And it looks quite slippery.”

“But that log is the only way to reach the Spirit Mountain,” said Wukong. “You must believe that it’s safe. Watch me!”



The monkey hopped onto the log and ran across the river and back. “See?” he said. “It’s safe.”

Bajie snorted. “You don’t weigh much, Wukong. But if I step on that log, it will break.”

“I believe Wukong,” said Wujing. “We must walk across the log.”

“Follow me, Master,” said Wukong. He pulled



the Tang Monk toward the log.

The monk trembled with fear. “Don’t make me walk across that! I’ll fall into the river and drown!”

“Let’s just fly over the river,” suggested Bajie. “We can carry Master and the horse.”

“No,” insisted Wukong. “The Tang Monk must make the entire journey by himself. We’re here to protect him, not to carry him. Buddha



won’t allow Master to have the True Scriptures if he doesn’t take every step himself.”

Just then an old man appeared in a boat. “I can take you across the river,” said the man.

“Thank you,” said the Tang Monk. He walked to the riverbank. “My companion wanted me to walk across that log, but—” The monk gasped.

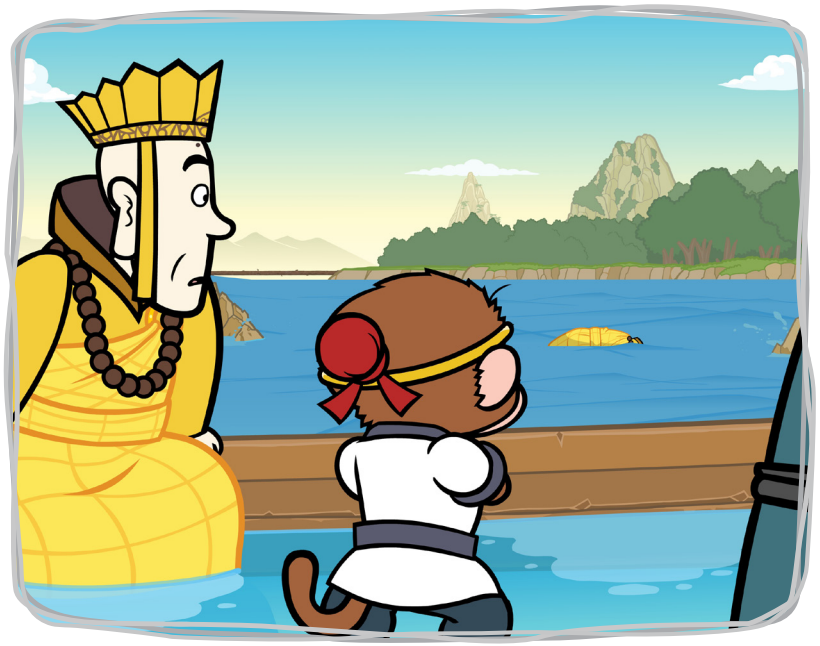
“There’s something wrong with your boat,”



he said to the man. “It has no bottom! Water is flowing right through it!”

“The boat is safe,” said the man. “Please climb in. Buddha is waiting.”

With a bit more hesitation, the Tang Monk stepped into the boat. He was shocked to find that he didn’t sink. He sat on the edge of the boat as Wujing led the horse aboard. Bajie and Wukong followed.



The boat glided swiftly across the river. Suddenly there was a splash.

The Tang Monk looked at the water and saw a body floating downstream. He screamed. “A man has drowned!”

Wukong put his hand on the monk’s shoulder and smiled. “It’s you, Master.”

“What?” said the monk. “Me?”

“Wukong is right!” cried Bajie. “It *is* you!”



"Look again, Master," said Wujing, smiling.

The Tang Monk looked at the body more carefully. It was wearing the same Buddhist robe that he was wearing. "It *is* me," said the monk quietly. "But how . . . ?"

"You got rid of your mortal body, Master," said Wukong. "You're a spirit now."

"You're one of us!" Bajie beamed.

The boat soon reached the other riverbank,



and the travelers stepped out. As they walked up the slope of the Spirit Mountain, the Tang Monk laughed in amazement.

"I feel so light!" he said. "I feel like I could run right up this mountain!"

"Good," said Bajie. "Perhaps you could carry me?"

Everybody laughed as they continued up the mountain.